

Final Project Lab - Product Management Assessment

Product-Manager Deliverable | Written by Brian McCarthy

Overview

This answer sheet assesses the StreamLean Gaming scenario by identifying what went well, what could have gone better, and specific recommendations to strengthen product management practices across strategy, discovery, execution, launch, and continuous improvement.

Step 2: Observations - What Went Well

#	Observation
1	Executive leadership recognized the need for a more structured product-management approach. Claire Henderson saw that profits had stagnated and moved beyond relying only on engineering-led ideas, which created urgency and sponsorship for a stronger product-development model.
2	The company created a dedicated cross-functional team with clear specialist roles. Product management, project management, and marketing were all represented, which helped connect vision, execution, and go-to-market planning instead of treating them as separate afterthoughts.
3	Emily Dawson brought strong product-domain fit. Her background in educational game design, math, and child-centered learning gave the product vision credibility and helped ensure the new activities were both fun and instructionally useful.
4	The team invested in customer discovery and market research before building. They gathered input from educators and parents, visited schools, ran focus groups, and studied math competitions, giving the team evidence about real user needs rather than relying only on assumptions.
5	The product concept had a differentiated value proposition. The magical adventure theme, hidden-treasure math challenges, player competition, and class-level competitions gave the product a clearer reason to stand out from competing educational games.
6	Product and engineering collaboration was built into the development phase. Emily worked closely with the technical team to keep the games fun while aligning them with educational standards, reducing the risk of building something entertaining but not instructionally sound.
7	Launch execution was coordinated well. Michael kept implementation organized and on track while Sarah built awareness through education conferences and influencers, leading to a smooth launch and strong reception from educators and parents.

Step 3: Observations - What Could Have Gone Better

#	Observation
1	The scenario does not show a measurable product strategy. The team had a strong creative vision, but it did not define explicit goals such as adoption, retention, learning improvement, teacher satisfaction, revenue targets, or competitive positioning metrics.
2	There is no clear MVP or phased roadmap. The team appears to move from research into a full launch, but the scenario does not describe how features were prioritized, what was intentionally deferred, or how risk was reduced through staged delivery.
3	Child-user testing is underdeveloped. Educators and parents were consulted, but the scenario gives limited evidence that children repeatedly tested prototypes, gameplay difficulty, reward loops, accessibility, or engagement before the final launch.
4	Decision rights between the product manager and project manager could be clearer. Michael controlled schedule and budget while Emily owned vision, but the scenario does not explain who made trade-off decisions when scope, cost, usability, and educational outcomes competed.
5	Post-launch learning and product operations are missing. The company celebrated the launch, but the scenario does not describe analytics, customer feedback intake, backlog grooming, release planning, support processes, or continuous improvement after launch.

Step 4: Recommendations - Improve Product Management

#	Recommendation
1	Establish product OKRs and success metrics before development starts. StreamLean should define measurable outcomes such as active classroom usage, student completion rates, teacher NPS, parent satisfaction, concept mastery improvement, renewal rate, and revenue contribution.
2	Create a product roadmap with MVP, beta, and full-release phases. The roadmap should prioritize the smallest valuable version first, validate core gameplay and learning outcomes, and then expand into multiplayer, class competitions, national leaderboards, and additional math topics.
3	Implement a continuous discovery process. The product manager should run recurring interviews, prototype tests, usability sessions, and classroom pilots with students, teachers, and parents so product decisions remain grounded in evidence throughout the lifecycle.
4	Formalize product governance and decision-making. Use a RACI model or decision framework that clarifies who owns product vision, budget trade-offs, prioritization, acceptance criteria, release readiness, and go/no-go decisions.
5	Build a post-launch product-management operating rhythm. StreamLean should review analytics, support tickets, educator feedback, competitor updates, and learning-outcome data on a regular cadence, then translate insights into backlog items, experiments, and release improvements.